so-called local Mafiosi who have undermined the creation of a stable legal foundation for the market economy.' These were the unintended winners in the transition process.[102] Still, Stiglitz concludes by labelling these former Communist businessmen as 'pragmatists who wanted to get ahead in the system. If the system required that they join the Communist Party, that did not seem an overly excessive price to pay.' He then continues: 'While some of these "practical men" were ready to steal as much of the state's wealth for themselves and their friends as they could get away with, they were clearly no left-wing ideologues… It had taken a long time for us finally to stop judging people by whether they were or were not Communists during the old regime – or even by what they did under the old regime.'[103]

With or without ideology, innovative privatisation has created social tensions, has compromised both the market economy and democratic ideas, and ultimately created distortions in the markets, where small and medium entrepreneurs with no political friends were displaced by comrades in business. As we shall see in the following chapter, all these created fertile grounds (and sometimes just a good excuse) for the rise of populists in Poland and Hungary, and elsewhere, who continue to use the Communist argument.

But can former Communists really be blamed for all the troubles and vices of the post-Communist societies? Are they really the cause of the populism in Eastern Europe? Is there a danger of a return to Communism? To admit the truth, the new democratic political elites in Eastern Europe have not always lived up to their promises either. The first battalions of these usually consisted of uncompromising, often naïve idealists who had never run anything other than a literary society or a semi-illegal intellectual journal. (However, even the most experienced macroeconomists and policy analysts would probably not have been able to do much better in the circumstances.) What happened was that, all across Eastern Europe, a few years after the first democratic elections, pioneering democratic governments fell and were, by the late 1990s, replaced by political parties which had been fancily rebranded either by truly progressive ex-Communists or simply by those who were less scrupulous and did not mind laying spurious claim to being Western-style Social Democrats or even Liberals. This was certainly no ordinary comeback to Communism, but an advent of post-Communists, and the new political parties were at least partially to be blamed for that.